

Firstword

You saw it. Say it. Don't let paperwork be the reason it wasn't reported.

Context

The system that should protect children has a human flaw...

The Megan Khung Case, 2020

A 5-year-old died after months of abuse. The preschool had observed visible injuries but their report to ECDA did not fully describe the severity. Multiple agencies missed the escalation window. The report was filtered through the worker's interpretation before it ever reached CPS.

14.5%

rise in high-risk child
abuse cases since 2024

2024

Domestic Violence Tools - Domestic Violence Risk Triage (DVRT)
& Domestic Violence Risk Assessment (DVRA) tools were
introduced to professionals

Training has scaled. But the moment of observation – what a teacher notices, what she writes down, how much she says – remains **unstructured, emotionally filtered, and inconsistent.**

Problem

Closing the gap between emotion and professional assessment

The Halo Effect

Perpetrators of family violence often present well publicly. A teacher who finds a caregiver 'nice' unconsciously discounts what she sees.

The social service agency later in 2025 clarified to the panel that the community workers also considered that there were no known prior instances of excessive discipline and “mother and child have shown to have a **positive** relationship”.

Bandwidth Fatigue

A social worker managing 20 cases deprioritises ambiguous signals. Cognitive load reduces reporting completeness.

Motivated reasoning

'The injury could have a reasonable explanation.' Workers avoid the discomfort of being wrong about a family they know.

When questioned by school staff and Beyond Social Services' community workers, Megan's mother said that some of the bruises were due to the **disciplinary action** inflicted by her, while others were injuries she got when Megan fell while cycling.

Narrative softening

When writing notes after the fact, workers naturally soften language. 'Significant bruising' becomes 'some marks'.

"In particular, the incident report to ECDA did not record that injuries were sustained on the **torso** area, which included a possible burn mark or wound of some kind and the extent of the other injuries," the review panel said in its report.

The problem is not **knowledge** – it is the **gap** between what workers **observe** and what they report.

Framework

Singapore's child protection framework already has the answer

Sector-Specific Screening Guide (SSSG)

Frontline professional – teacher, nurse, preschool educator, volunteer

Observes signs → structures observation → decides: escalate internally?

Cannot contact NAVH directly

Child Abuse Reporting Guide (CARG)

Designated child protection person within each organisation

Receives SSSG record → runs CARG assessment → decides: report to NAVH, refer, or monitor

Only CARG users contact NAVH

Screening & Response Priority Tool

NAVH / MSF Protective Service (PSV) – statutory authority

Triages CARG report → decides: PSV investigation, Tier 1 community referral, or no statutory action

Out of scope for this tool

The Gap

SSSG and CARG exist — so why does the problem persist?

What SSSG/CARG does well

- Provides evidence-based, structured decision criteria
- Separates the frontline observer from the reporting decision
- Localised to Singapore laws, culture, and sector contexts
- Part of the global SDM[®] system, proven across US, Canada, Australia

What SSSG/CARG cannot do alone

- Cannot force complete or accurate observation capture
- Cannot prevent emotional softening in written notes
- Adds 3+ hours of documentation work per case for social workers
- Still relies on human recall – what the worker remembered vs. saw

Firstword sits at the SSSG layer and fixes the input – so every downstream decision is made on **complete, accurate, unfiltered data**.

How Firstword works in the reporting process

01 Observe

Teacher notices signs of concern – injury, behaviour, or caregiver conduct

02 Speak

Opens Firstword, taps record. Speaks freely for 60-90 seconds about what she saw and heard

03 Review

AI extracts SSSG indicators from transcript. Worker confirms or corrects – keeps professional judgement in the loop

04 Risk Score

Framework weights indicators automatically. Risk level (High / Moderate / Low) derived from observations, not gut feel

SSSG → CARG handoff

Firstword outputs a structured observation document – not a NAVH report. This document goes to the CARG-trained colleague within the organisation, who makes the formal reporting determination. The CARG user then contacts NAVH if warranted. Firstword never touches NAVH.

Offline Runtime

Ollama is running.

All Cases

7 shown



New

Search Case ID

CASE-20260523-0007

Escalate from Tier 1 to Tier 2
23/05/2026, 15:19:05 SGT

CASE-20260523-0006

Escalate from Tier 1 to Tier 2
23/05/2026, 15:13:40 SGT

CASE-20260523-0005

Continue Monitoring
23/05/2026, 15:04:27 SGT

CASE-20260523-0004

Escalate from Tier 1 to Tier 2
23/05/2026, 15:02:29 SGT

CASE-20260523-0003

Continue Monitoring
23/05/2026, 14:55:55 SGT

CASE-20260523-0002

Audio Recording

Temporary local recording for transcription, summary, and recommendation support.

00:00

idle

Confirm consent and comply with organisational recording policies before starting.

Start recording

Structured Summary

CASE-20260523-0007 · 23/05/2026, 15:19:05 SGT

Case Overview

A teacher observed drawings depicting a larger figure hitting a smaller figure during an activity.

Key Concerns

Potential depiction of physical abuse or aggression

Need for further assessment to understand context

Observations

Children engaged in drawing activities

Drawings showed figures with one figure hitting another

Reported Statements

No information recorded

Moderate child protection concern

Escalate from Tier 1 to Tier 2

The summary contains moderate safety or risk indicators. For an SSSG user, this supports discussion with the organisation's CARG-trained user. For a CARG user, it supports considering Tier 2 protective intervention pathways while applying professional judgment.

This is a recommendation support tool and does not replace professional judgment.

Contributing Indicators

Depiction of violence in drawings

Possible indication of exposure to harmful situations or behaviors

Why Voice?

People say more when they speak: Unfiltered, Faster, More complete.

Speech bypasses the editorial filter

- When typing, workers unconsciously soften language. Speech captures the raw account – 'significant bruising on the upper arm' rather than 'some marks'.

Speed is everything in a crisis moment

- A teacher has 2 minutes between classes. Tapping through a form is not realistic. Speaking for 90 seconds is.

Verbatim quotes are preserved

- When a child says something significant, the exact words matter evidentially. Voice capture preserves them before memory degrades.

On-device only – no audio stored

- Web Speech API transcribes in the browser. Audio is never transmitted, never stored. Only the text transcript is kept in session memory.